are beautifully done, artfully and tastefully with an old grass bank to sit on, with the backdrop of Table Mountain framing it.

We bat first and Shoaib Akhtar is bowling. Shoaib is famous for being possibly the fastest bowler of all time. I sat and watched him on television in the 1999 World Cup in England, running in like some sort of velociraptor hunting out prey; smart and methodical and unflinchingly destructive. Seeing him in the flesh, in real life, really is like seeing some sort of extinct beast, brought back to life in a different universe by a quirk of genetic engineering. He really is that other-worldly. When we bat, he bowls a ball that hits 100 miles an hour on the speed gun. Nick Knight just calmly tucks it off his hip for one, as if it was nothing. This is a different universe. Everything is heightened. Everything is unflinching.

This time, I'm not batting in a fielder's helmet and its extra bar either, although when I see what Akhtar has just bowled, I wish I was. We score 246/8 in our 50 overs and I am spared needing to bat.

It's the first time my dad and grandad have ever seen me play for England. They've flown out, breathing it in, rubbing their eyes too. I am opening the bowling and, two overs in, Inzamam-ul-Haq arrives at the crease. Inzi is similar in presence and stature to Shoaib Akhtar. As he sets up to face his first ball, his stance, the way he is hunched over his bat, both idiosyncratically elegant and cumbersome, is so familiar to me that it appears he has been green-screened on to the pitch, like I'm in some kind of futuristic simulator. It's *the* Inzamam-ul-Haq. I run in, enthused by the vision of Shoaib I have just seen. I'm not even trying to bowl fast or run fast, I just do. Something else is in my system, willing me on, carrying me towards the wicket, ushering that ball out of my hand. I know it's a good one immediately. Bowling is like that; as soon as it's left your hand, you often just know. Inzi thinks the ball is going straight and opens his body to try and hit it through midwicket, on the leg side. I know it's going to shape, I've felt it tell me that as it's left my hand. As it does, swinging aggressively and suddenly from a middle stump line away from him, his famous outline is frozen, almost painting an S-shape in the air, realising the ball is not going where he expected and trying to adjust. It's too late. It's hit the outside edge and flies to Nick Knight, who catches the ball at his throat, mouth wide open as if he can't believe what's happened either.